American history of the Wall, one must explore and read across the scores of cultural identifications the Wall's interconnected narratives of liberty and restraint. Such an exploration places cultural production in relation to politics not as an oddity or an afterthought but instead as forms of expressive diplomacy, resistance, and contestation of state narratives. Taking this approach permits a deeper consideration of the complexity of U.S. geopolitics and the imposed limits of freedom. Our walls—past and present, as well as under construction and in contention—directly challenge the notion of a historically indivisible nation. Americans' ongoing attachment to the story of the Berlin Wall as a site of triumph connected to American democracy, or as a litmus test for how divisive our internal and external borders can be, is fueled by more than a generation of creative agents who reflected on the Wall and other dividing lines as persistent structures in the American culture.

This book attempts to move beyond the tendency of American–Berlin Wall discourse that relies on strict binaries to understand the divided city: *here* and *there, East* and *West, capitalist* and *socialist, truth* and *propaganda, us* and *them,* and the simplistic formulation of a *good* and a *bad* side, without room for nuance and complexity, let alone tracing connections to our own domestic crises of division in democracy.

Between 1961 and 1989, American cultural figures drawn to Berlin demonstrated an enhanced clarity about American culture by turning to face this ideological border forged in concrete. Since 1989, with the dismantled Wall in ruins, they continued this focus within a city characterized by its visible scars, redemptive aims, and networks of American affiliation. These artists and writers navigated the intricate and ever-shifting border system between East and West Berlin, which offered interactions with a range of individuals and groups that included American GIs, East German border guards, state officials and grassroots activists (from both sides), dissident artists and writers, and fellow Americans in exile. As they explored the divided city, they encountered a new generation of memorials and monuments that made competing claims about the true trajectory of free and totalitarian regimes.

The products of their artistic labor eventually manifested in an impressive range of published works of cultural regard and political weight that have come to occupy central features, texts, and tenets of art making and activism. This book hones in on a particular cohort of artists and writers